



Episode VII Special Edition

This parody explores what would happen if George Lucas were to re-release The Last Jedi in a few years. <https://digit.in/jul20-55>



Han shot first

The depressingly detailed article on the history of updates made to a single scene from Star Wars. <https://digit.in/jul20-56>

Movies getting patched

Leave our films alone, please.

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ovies can be monumental components of human culture. We remember scenes, wear the costumes of

the heroes, appropriate the dialogues in regular life, and make fan movies to extend the experience. Nowadays though, movies are becoming as fragile and problematic as software. This is because movies have started to get delta updates, and are being pushed into theatres before completion.

The earliest examples of these were the colourised versions of old black and white movies. These “improvements” were not really what they claimed to be, and just made the movie look odd. The works of Sergei Eisenstein, Alfred Hitchcock, Akira Kurosawa, or Satyajit Ray were never meant to be colourised. Imagine modern classics such as Dr Strangelove, Clerks or Pi being colourised. The black and white film is part of the whole experience.

Then there were the Star Wars movies. George Lucas added additional stormtroopers and beasts of burden in one of the early panning shots of Tatooine, something that has been parodied in YouTube videos many times. In a 2004 re-release of Return of the Jedi, a shot from Naboo was added, which looks horribly out of place because it is 2000s graphics in a 1980s film. They also replaced Sebastian Shaw, the actor who played Darth Vader in the original trilogy with Hayden Christensen, the actor who played Anakin Skywalker in the prequel trilogy. Then of course, there is the most controversial post release edit of all time, the bit where

Han shoots Greedo. In the original release, Han shoots Greedo. In the 1997 special edition, Greedo shoots Han first. In the 2004 DVD, both of them appear to shoot each other at the same time, Greedo misses, while Han is on target. When it released on Disney+, there was another, slight change made to the scene, where it again appears as if Greedo shoots first. Just make up your mind already! And stick to a decision, please! We would not be surprised if this keeps getting changed.

At times the changes made after the release are things that nobody will even notice. For a 2012 3D re release of Titan-



Who shot first?

ic, James Cameron being the perfectionist that he was, changed the starfield in the background of the sinking ship in a shot, because the stars in the sky were not in their accurate positions for the time when the ship sank in 1912. This was a change made after astrophysicist Neil deGrasse Tyson pointed it out.

Now, technologies have advanced so much that movies are getting updates even before their theatrical runs have finished. Universal pushed out a version of Cats with updated graphics to movie theatres, within a week after releasing it! At least the makers of Sonic went back to the drawing board.

It is a good thing that studios like EA or Gameloft are not into movie

production, or we might have got microtransactions for scenes, and additional content dropping over the years as the studios continue to work on it. What if Amazon starts releasing the Tolkien Legendarium as a Service, or the next season of Black Mirror gets early access with an extra episode for those who pick it up, or Race 4 lets you pick costumes for the cast. Things are probably heading in this direction anyway, as it is very easy for some movies such as Bandersnatch to get DLCs. I really just want my movies to be left alone once they are released. Still, in the interests of not sound-

ing like an old person, we wouldn't say no to a couple of extra seasons of Game of Thrones tying up all the loose ends. Like seriously, what happened to the Faceless Men, the Reeds, the Iron Bank and whatever conspiracy that Varys was hatching with Illyrio Mopatis? What if years later HBO decides to release the answers to these questions because of a petition by fans, the same way that

Warner Bros caved in to pressure and released the Snyder Cut (which could be managed just by digitally adding rain to the whole movie). It does not stop there, if movies keep taking all the bad ideas from the gaming industry, maybe there will be time sinks where we have to come back every few hours to gain unlockables and there is a digital black market for movie extras and director's commentary.

Maybe what the studios need to do is borrow from the good aspects of software engineering, instead of the problematic ones. Keeping it simple is a great principle. When it comes to Cats, don't make the movie. For the rest, please get it right the first time! 🍿